

THE HANDS THAT FEED
Chanchalapathi Dasa and Shridhar Venkat (front left and right) with Akshaya Patra kitchen staff in Bengaluru

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **The founding ideal of Akshaya Patra is 'no child in India would be deprived of education because of hunger'**
- **It now feeds over 2.35 million children in 23,000 schools**
- **It has 78 hi-tech kitchens in 16 states and three Union territories**
- **Its next goal: to serve 3 million mid-day meals and an additional 3 million servings of morning nutrition**

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Much before dawn breaks over the Bengaluru skyline, an assembly line kicks into production. Its processes, in which gravity plays a key role, flow from top to bottom across three levels. Tonnes of rice, vegetables and cooking ingredients stored on the uppermost floor are released to the level immediately below, where pre-processing takes place through specialised machines. Then, these are funneled down a chute into 10 large steam-fed cooking cauldrons that churn out 2,100 kg of steaming rice and 3,600 litres of piping hot sambar. As each batch is ready, they are transferred to insulated steel containers and ferried out by a conveyor belt into vans waiting outside. By 8 am, this kitchen on the outskirts of Bengaluru winds down. It is one of the 78 kitchens run by the Akshaya Patra Foundation